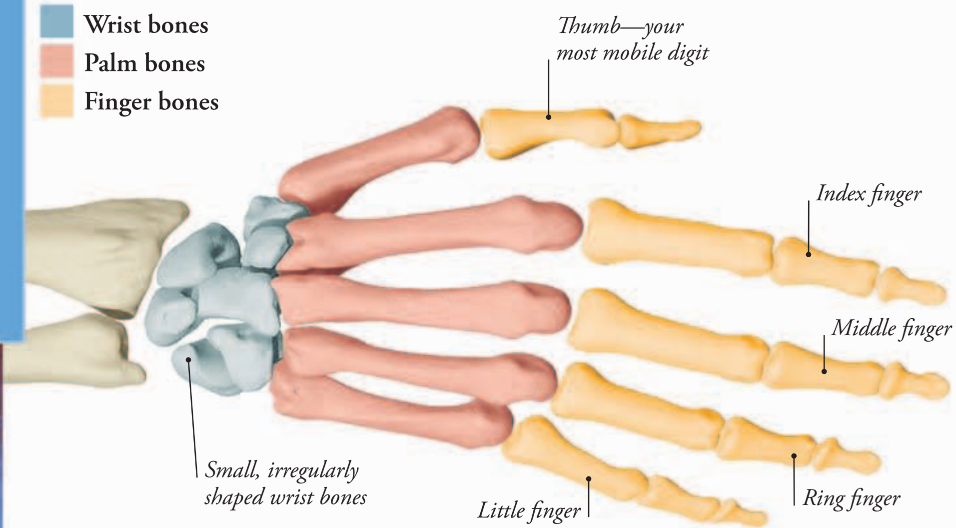
Reaching out

Your body has the perfect tools for carrying out a variety of daily tasks, from holding a pen with delicate precision to throwing a ball with great force. The intricate framework of small bones in your hands is worked by the many muscles in your arms and together they are able to perform a multitude of movements.

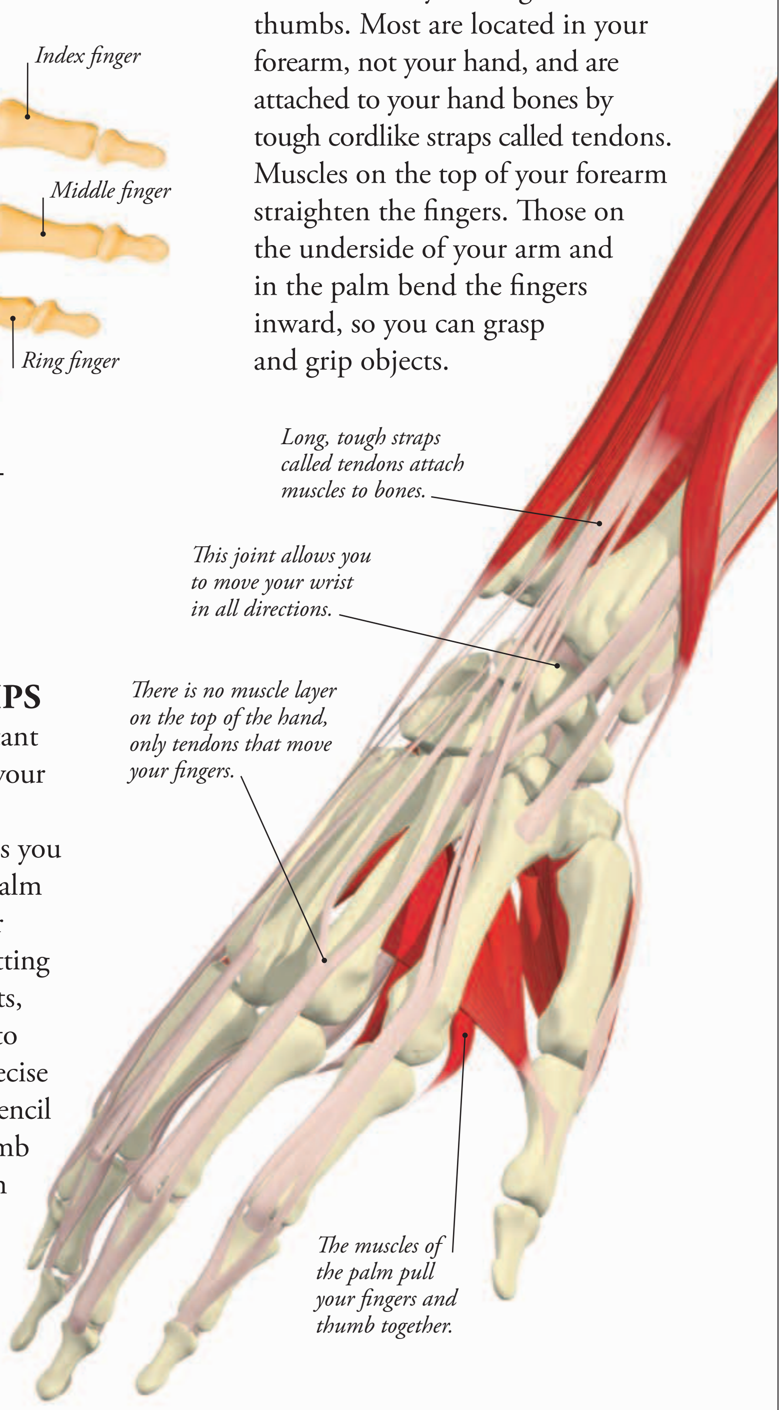


MOVE THOSE FINGERS

It takes about 30 muscles in each hand to move your fingers and thumbs. Most are located in your forearm, not your hand, and are attached to your hand bones by tough cordlike straps called tendons. Muscles on the top of your forearm straighten the fingers. Those on the underside of your arm and in the palm bend the fingers inward, so you can grasp and grip objects.

FLEXIBLE FRAMEWORK

Each hand is made up of 27 bones divided into three groups—eight wrist bones, five palm bones, and 14 finger (digit) bones. Some people are born with an extra digit, usually next to the little finger. The record is seven fingers on each hand!



▲ HOLDING A BRUSH *Small muscles in the hand press the thumb and fingers together to form a secure grip on an object.*

GETTING TO GRIPS

One of the most important features of your hand is your thumb. This digit has a unique joint that enables you to move it across your palm to touch the tips of your fingers. In addition to letting you pick up small objects, the thumb enables you to perform delicate and precise tasks. Try picking up a pencil without using your thumb and you'll see how much you rely on this digit.